

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This editorial appeared in a local newspaper:



McSleepers drive crisis home

We all know that Hong Kong has a housing crisis, but did you know the number of “McSleepers” – those sleeping overnight at McDonald’s – has increased nearly 600 percent over the past five years?

A recent survey found 334 “McSleepers” sleeping overnight at McDonald’s 24-hour restaurants, and that number is most likely only a small part of the total.

I can’t help wondering whether the homeless would have been thrown out onto the streets if they had curled up for a nap in other restaurants or in air-conditioned places. So staff at the McDonald’s should be praised for showing kindness to people without a place to sleep at night.

According to the survey, reasons why people choose to sleep at McDonald’s include staying in an air-conditioned environment, security and the use of bathrooms. Some “McSleepers” complain that the government is not doing enough to reduce homelessness. They claim that the conditions in the homeless shelters provided by the government are so bad that they actually prefer McDonald’s to having to return to such shelters.

The question is how long this can go on. If the number of “McSleepers” grows, sooner or later McDonald’s will have to ask if it can still manage to provide a safe place for these people to sleep. Those sleeping in their restaurants take up space, often make customers feel uncomfortable and at times make their restaurants difficult to keep clean.

Your class is doing a project on homeless people in Hong Kong. Your group has been asked to discuss the issue of the homeless sleeping in 24-hour McDonald’s restaurants. You may want to talk about:

- what problems homeless people face
- why they go to McDonald’s
- how this affects McDonald’s
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like to go to McDonald’s?
2. Do you ever visit McDonald’s late at night?
3. Where else do homeless people sleep?
4. Do you think McDonald’s is a caring company?
5. What would be the most difficult thing about sleeping in McDonald’s?
6. What types of people are more likely to be homeless?
7. Should private companies do more to help solve the problem of homelessness?
8. Why does homelessness exist in wealthy cities?